



Working with .csv files

In an earlier lesson, you explored comma separated values (.csv) files and how to import them into a Google Sheet or download them from a website. Data analysts use .csv files often, so throughout this course you will use .csv files to transfer data into data analysis programs for further analysis and visualization. .csv files are plain text files with an organized table structure that includes rows and columns. The values in each row are separated by commas. The table structure makes .csv files easy to understand, edit, manipulate, and use for data analysis.

A major advantage of .csv files is their widespread compatibility. They can be imported and exported by a vast range of data analysis tools and software programs.

Download .csv files

To use .csv files and upload them to data analysis programs you will first need to download them to your local device. Downloading a .csv file from a website can vary depending on your operating system or internet browser. Here are some ways you can download a .csv file:

- Click the download link or .csv attachment: Locate the link for the .csv file or attachment on the website. Click on it, and the download process will start.

- **Right-click and Save:** Right-click on the data table or element containing the .csv data. Choose Save as... or a similar option. Name the file and make sure the extension on the file is “.csv”.
- **Force download:** You can use the Alt key on your keyboard while clicking the link. This will trigger the download, and you will be able to find the .csv file in your Downloads folder.

Note: When using the Chrome browser or ChromeOS, .csv files may open in a new tab instead of downloading to your machine. If this happens, follow these instructions:

- Select File from the menu bar, then select Save as Google Sheets. This will open the .csv file as a Google Sheet.
- Select File from the menu bar, then select Download from the dropdown menu, then select Comma Separated Values (.csv).

Upload .csv files

You will often need to upload .csv files during the data analysis process. Here is how you do this:

- **Locate the upload option:** Each data analysis platform will have a designated button, menu option, or drag and drop area labeled Upload or Import. This is where you will upload your .csv file.
- **Choose your .csv file:** Click Upload or Import on the platform you are using to open your file explorer. Select your .csv file. If you just downloaded a .csv file from the web, it will be located in your computer's Downloads folder.
- **Initiate the upload:** Once you've selected your .csv file, click Upload or Import. The platform may display a progress bar or message indicating that the upload is complete.

Note: Some platforms have restrictions on the file size or format of .csv files. Make sure your .csv files adhere to these requirements before uploading.

Key takeaways

Data analysis programs help us extract insights and knowledge from data. Using .csv files is essential in data analysis. Understanding how to easily download data from the web or add your data to these programs will allow you to complete data cleaning, visualizations, analysis, and so much more!